

ANI

ADVOCATING HIS CAUSE
AIMIM president Asaduddin Owaisi campaigning in Hyderabad, Apr. 28

THE EXISTENCE OF MUSLIM-CENTRIC PARTIES HAS FRAGMENTED THE MUSLIM VOTE FURTHER AND HELPED THE BJP

highest it reached was in 1980 when it touched 10 per cent, with 49 Muslim elected MPs. That number has been waning since. In 2014, the BJP became the first party with a simple majority to not have any elected Muslim MP. In 2019, of the 30 states and six UTs, 21 states and four UTs did not send a single Muslim MP. Of the 28 Muslim Lok Sabha MPs in the 17th Lok Sabha, 24 came from the seven states (including J&K, which was a state then) with the highest Muslim population. That trend, in fact, has been continuing since Independence, with more than 50 per cent of all Muslim MPs ever elected coming from 29 Muslim-concentrated seats.

In recent years, however, there is a growing clamour among Muslims to change what till now has been just symbolic representation. "Political parties must not take Muslim votes for granted just because they are likely to vote against Modi," says Congress spokesperson Shama Mohamed. "Besides proactive focus on the socio-economic issues impacting Muslims, their representation in organisational set-ups and ticket distribution must go up too. Political parties must promote educated, progressive Muslims who can bring in change, not rabid elements." The Congress could put its own house in order first. Of the 77 members (including permanent and special invitees) of the Congress Working Committee, only five are Muslims and just one a member of any legislative body.

The loss of faith in the Congress and the subsequent failure of the regional secular parties to protect their interests have resulted in the growth of Muslim-centric parties such as the AIMIM (All-India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen) and the AIUDF. However, these parties have often remained region-specific—partly recalling how the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML), founded in 1948, remained largely a Kerala party. But unlike the latter, their existence has also further fragmented the Muslim vote; most non-BJP parties allege that they have served to help the BJP. The AIMIM, for instance, has partnered with the BSP in UP and fielded candidates in several Muslim-majority seats. Their candidates are most likely to eat into the votes of the INDIA bloc, indirectly giving the BJP an edge. During the 2017 UP assembly election, BSP supremo Mayawati fielded 99 Muslim candidates. Of these, only five won but the rest ensured that the Muslim votes got split between the BSP and the SP-Congress alliance and the BJP walked away with 313 of the 403 seats. This time, Mayawati has fielded 23 Muslim candidates in UP as against four by the SP and two by the Congress.

Leaders of the community hope that the common Muslim voter will rise above fragmented political affiliation and vote with a unified objective. This is what is expected in Assam, where poll observers say the 34 per cent Muslims have strategically voted for the Congress candidates this time so that the division of votes between the Grand Old Party and AIUDF doesn't benefit the BJP—a trend that is likely to determine the outcomes in the Nagaon and Karimganj constituencies. The Muslims want to be seen not just as a religious group with significant electoral might but as a population group in urgent need of socio-political and economic uplift. The communal narrative this election may have done little to ease their perception of existential threat, but for their meaningful participation in the democratic process, one will have to look beyond Election 2024. ■

***with* Prashant Srivastava, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar and Moazum Mohammad**